

Not to be confused with [Egyptian Museum](#) or [National Museum of Egyptian Civilization](#).

The **Grand Egyptian Museum (GEM;** [Egyptian Arabic](#): المتحف المصري الكبير *al-Maṭḥaf al-Miṣriyy al-Kabir*) is an [archaeological](#) and national museum located about 2 kilometres (1.2 mi) from the [Giza Pyramid Complex](#), in [Giza](#), Egypt. Dedicated to [Ancient Egypt](#) and its culture, society, and artifacts, it is the largest museum in the world for a single civilization.^{[3][4]}

The museum was announced in 1992,^[3] actual construction began in 2005,^[5] and it was fully completed in 2023^[6] at a cost of \$1.2 billion.^[7] Trial opening began in October 2024, and the official opening took place on 1 November 2025.^[8]

The museum houses a collection of Egyptian artifacts from various periods of Egyptian civilization, from the [Predynastic Period](#) to [Roman Egypt](#). There are an estimated total of over 100,000 artifacts,^[9] including at least 20,000 that were displayed for the first time ever, such as the complete King [Tutankhamun](#) collection comprising 5,398 pieces, on display in a 7,500 m² (81,000 ft²) section of the museum.^{[10][11]} Some newly-restored pieces will be displayed for the first time, such as the second solar ship of [Khufu](#),^[12] the collection of [Queen Hetepheres](#) (mother of King [Khufu](#)),^[13] and the collection of [Yuya](#) and [Thuya](#) (parents of [Queen Tiye](#)).

The museum covers a total area of 500,000 m² (5,400,000 ft²),^{[14][15]} with a built-up area of 167,000 m² (1,800,000 ft²)^[16] and floor area of 81,000 m² (870,000 ft²).^[17] It will also host permanent exhibition galleries, temporary exhibitions, special exhibitions, a children's museum, and virtual and large-format screens with a total floor area of 32,000 m² (340,000 ft²).

The museum was built by a joint venture of Egyptian [Orascom Construction](#) and the Belgian [BESIX Group](#).^[18]

History

The Hanging Obelisk of [Pharaoh Ramesses II](#) in front of the GEM

The Grand Egyptian Museum concept originated in the early 1990s with [Farouk Hosni](#), who served as [Minister of Culture](#) from 1987 to 2011. According to Hosni, the [Egyptian Museum](#) in [Tahrir](#) had become old-fashioned and "Every time I visited the museum it gave me headaches and depression and its restoration was a disaster".^[19]

The project was officially launched by the government in 1992 under President [Hosni Mubarak](#), who announced plans to build a new museum to house a larger collection of artifacts and to consolidate ancient treasures. In 2002, the foundation stone for the project was laid,^[20] and in 2005 the actual construction work began.^[21]

Opening and postponement

The Grand Egyptian Museum's opening has been postponed several times:

- **2020–2021:** The Grand Egyptian Museum was scheduled to open in 2020, but was postponed to 2021 due to the [COVID-19 pandemic](#), which impacted preparations and logistics.^[22]
- **2021–2023:** After postponing its opening from 2020 to the last quarter of 2021 due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the Grand Egyptian Museum faced additional delays due to ongoing logistical challenges, including the completion of construction work, the transportation of artifacts, and preparations for trial operation. It was announced that the official opening was postponed to the end of 2022 or early 2023,^[23] with limited trial operations expected to begin during that period.^[24] The head of the Egyptian Tourist Guides Syndicate, Basem Halaka, announced that the Grand Egyptian Museum would open by the end of 2023.^[25]
- **2023–2024:** Minister of Tourism Ahmed Issa stated that the Grand Egyptian Museum will open in May 2024.^[26] This did not happen, but the museum was opened for a trial period to four thousand visitors in October 2024.^{[27][28][29]} After that, the final opening date was set for 3 July 2025.^[30]
- **2025:** The Ministry of Tourism and Antiquities announced that it had postponed the opening of the Grand Egyptian Museum, which was scheduled to open on 3 July 2025.^[31] In another statement to local newspapers, Prime Minister Mostafa Madbouly said, "All readings indicate that the existing conflict will continue for a while and will not end in a few days, and therefore will have repercussions on the region and on all expected events"^{[32][33]} referring to the ongoing [military conflict between Iran and Israel](#).

Final official opening date

On 6 August 2025, Prime Minister [Mostafa Madbouly](#) announced that President [Abdel Fattah el-Sisi](#) had agreed to set the GEM's opening date for 1 November,^{[34][8]} though it was temporarily closed from 15 October to 3 November 2025, inclusive. The museum resumed receiving visitors during official working hours on 4 November, the 103rd anniversary of the [discovery of the tomb of Tutankhamun](#).^[35]

Egyptian President Abdel Fattah al-Sisi with representatives of foreign countries at the official opening of the Grand Egyptian Museum

The GEM was fully inaugurated on 1 November 2025. The opening ceremony was attended by Egyptian president [Abdel Fatah El-Sisi](#), the [First Lady of Egypt](#), as well as representatives

of foreign countries and prominent public figures such as [King Philippe of Belgium](#), [King Felipe VI of Spain](#), [Prince Albert II of Monaco](#), [Queen Rania of Jordan](#), [Queen Mary of Denmark](#), former [Grand-Duke Henri of Luxembourg](#), German President [Frank-Walter Steinmeier](#), Portuguese president [Marcelo Rebelo de Sousa](#), Greek Prime Minister [Kyriakos Mitsotakis](#), Hungarian Prime Minister [Viktor Orbán](#) and others.^{[[citation needed](#)]}

Visitors

Since October 2024, the museum has welcomed approximately 1.5 million visitors over 10 months, averaging 4,000 per day during the trial opening.^{[[36](#)]}

The museum received 18,000 visitors on its first day after its official opening to the public.^{[[37](#)][[38](#)]}

Collections and visit

The museum contains more than 100,000 artifacts distributed across 12 main permanent exhibition halls, as well as several other important halls.

Grand Hall (Atrium)

Grand Hall (Atrium) with [statue of Pharaoh Ramesses II](#)

The Atrium (Great Hall) of the Grand Egyptian Museum is the main entrance hall, spanning 10,000 square meters. Designed with a glass roof and a transparent façade, the [Giza Pyramids](#) are visible from inside.

It houses the statue of Pharaoh [Ramesses II](#) (11 meters, 83 t (183,000 lb)) and 20–30 large artifacts from different eras, making it an introductory exhibition. The Grand Staircase connects the 12 main exhibition halls. The statue was moved from Ramses Square in [Cairo](#) to its location (GEM) in 2006 and placed in the Grand Hall (Atrium) in 2018.^{[[39](#)]}

Grand Staircase

The staircase serves as a transitional gallery with more than 60 artifacts, leading to the 12 halls. Spanning 6,000 m² (65,000 ft²), the structure stands six stories tall (approximately 50 m (160 ft)), connecting the main lobby (atrium), temporary exhibition halls, and the main archaeological storeroom to the upper terrace, offering another view of the Giza Pyramids.^{[[40](#)]}

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Temple fragment



Grand Staircase



Pharaoh Hatshepsut



Ancient Egyptian deities



Pharaoh Akhenaten

It contains more than 60 artifacts, arranged in four thematic sections that represent a chronological journey (Royal Image: focuses on how and why pharaohs portrayed themselves, with royal statues; Divine Houses: on temples and the relationship between gods and pharaohs, with religious artwork; Gods & Kings: explores ancient Egyptian deities and their association with rulers; Funerary Section: displays stone coffins and sarcophagi from various eras, including a hermione (pyramid head) from the 13th Dynasty.

The 12 main halls

The exhibits cover about one-third of the total museum's 50 ha (5,400,000 ft²) grounds, displaying over 24,000 artefacts in 12 galleries arranged by time period (c. 3100 BCE – 400 CE). The artefacts were relocated from storage and museums in [Cairo](#), [Luxor](#), [Minya](#), [Sohag](#), [Assiut](#), [Beni Suef](#), [Faiyum](#), the [Nile Delta](#), and [Alexandria](#).^{[41][42]}

Halls 1–3 cover the prehistoric eras, the pre-dynastic eras, the early dynastic era, the [Old Kingdom](#) era, and the era of the first transition. 4–6 cover the [Middle Kingdom](#) and the Second Transition. 7–9 address the era of the [New Kingdom](#). Halls 10 through 12 cover the Third Transition, the Late Period, and the [Roman](#) and [Greek](#) Periods of Egypt.

Tutankhamun Halls



The golden mask of Pharaoh Tutankhamun inside the GEM

Two of the twelve halls are dedicated exclusively to the display of 5,398 artifacts belonging to King [Tutankhamun](#), the pharaoh of the Eighteenth Dynasty (ruled ca. 1332–1323 BC). This is the first time the entire collection has been displayed in one place, unlike the partial display at the Egyptian Museum in Tahrir Square previously. These two halls cover 7,000 square meters. [\[43\]](#)[\[44\]](#)



The [sarcophagus](#) of [Pharaoh Tutankhamun](#) inside the GEM

The central piece is the golden [Mask of Tutankhamun](#). There are three overlapping coffins, one made of gold (110 kg)^[45] and two of gold-plated wood. The Golden Throne is a chair covered in gold and silver, showing scenes of Tutankhamun and his wife, Ankhesenamun. There are statues of gods such as Anubis, as well as amulets and jewellery such as necklaces and rings. Daily tools include weapons (daggers, bows), furniture (beds, chairs), and dining utensils. There are [ushabti](#): small statues or figurines that were used in the afterlife to serve the king.^[46]

Tutankhamun's mummy will remain in the Valley of the Kings and will not be moved.^[47]

The halls are designed similarly to the original [Tomb of Tutankhamun](#) in the Valley of the Kings. Environmental control systems (such as temperature and humidity control) protect sensitive pieces, especially those made of gold, wood, and fabric.^[48]

Khufu Ships Museum



The [Khufu ship](#), a full-size [solar barque](#), at the GEM

The Khufu Ships Museum is a separate hall dedicated to displaying the two solar boats of King Khufu (the builder of the Great Pyramid), which are among the oldest wooden ships ever discovered, dating to approximately 4,600 years ago.^[49] Included is an interactive display explaining their proposed purpose(s) (perhaps to transport the king into the afterlife or his travels with the sun god Ra). It was transferred from the old [Giza Solar boat museum](#) in August 2021.^[50]

Children's Museum

The Children's Museum at GEM is an interactive space for children aged 6 to 12, emphasizing learning through play rather than traditional exhibits. It covers 5,000 square meters and offers experiences including interactive screens, [Augmented reality](#) (AR), and hands-on games, along with various visual exhibits and guided programs. It has been partially open since August 2024.^[51]

Conference Center



View of the [Pyramids of Giza](#) from the Grand Egyptian Museum

The Grand Egyptian Museum's Conference Center is designed to serve as an international hub for communication between museums and cultural institutions. It aims to host conferences, seminars, and educational events related to ancient Egyptian civilization and archaeology.

It covers a total area of 40,000 m² (430,000 ft²), divided into multi-use areas. It includes a main auditorium with a capacity of 1,000 seats, three seminar halls with a capacity of 250 seats each, exhibition spaces, meeting rooms, a business center, and a press room. There is also a 250-seat 3D theater. The design is inspired by ancient Pharaonic sites.^[52] Located within the main complex, it is accessible via the main atrium, with accessibility facilities for the disabled, including elevators and rest areas.

Temporary Exhibition Halls

Four Temporary Exhibition Halls are dedicated to the display of temporary artifacts or international exhibitions. These cover a total of 5,000 m² (54,000 ft²). These are part of 32,000 m² (340,000 ft²) dedicated to non-permanent displays.^[53]

Conservation Center



GEM Conservation Center

The Grand Egyptian Museum's Conservation Center is one of the largest conservation and restoration centers in the world and the largest center for the restoration of antiquities in the Middle East. It was established in 2006 and opened in 2010.^[53] It is located west of the museum and connected to it via a tunnel approximately 200 meters long. The center houses 19 laboratories, including those for the restoration of mummies, wood, stone, wall paintings, and metals, as well as laboratories for preventive conservation and scientific documentation. It also contains six storage rooms for preserving artifacts in controlled environmental conditions.^[54]

Design

The building design was decided by an [architectural competition](#) announced on 7 January 2002.^[55] The organisers received 1,557 entries from 82 countries, making it the second largest architectural competition in history.^[56] In the second stage of the competition, 20 entries submitted additional information on their designs. Judging was complete by 2 June 2003. The competition was won by architects [Róisín Heneghan](#) and Shi-Fu Peng, and their

company [Heneghan Peng Architects](#) of Ireland; the prize was US\$250,000.^[57] Heneghan Peng, [Buro Happold](#), [Arup](#) and [ACE Consulting Engineers \(Moharram and Bakhoum\)](#) collaborated on the design of the building. The landscape and site masterplan was designed by [West 8](#); the exhibition masterplan, [exhibition design](#), and [museumology](#) was led by [Atelier Brückner](#).^[58] On 2 February 2010, [Hill International](#) announced that [Egypt's Ministry of Culture](#) had signed a contract with a joint venture of [Hill](#) and EHA Consulting Engineers to provide project management services during the design and construction of the Grand Egyptian Museum.^[59]

The building's shape is a [chamfered](#) triangle. It sits on a site 2 kilometres (1.2 miles) northwest of the pyramids, near a motorway interchange. The building's north and south walls line up directly with the [Great Pyramid of Khufu](#) and the [Pyramid of Menkaure](#). The front of the museum includes a large plaza filled with date palms and a [façade](#) made of [translucent alabaster](#) stone. Inside the main entrance is a large [atrium](#) where large statues are exhibited.

The museum's facade is made of marble and glass, decorated with cartouches and ovals surrounding Egyptian hieroglyphs bearing the names of kings and queens.^[60]



The main gate of the Grand Egyptian Museum during the construction phase 2019



A guide map of the Grand Egyptian Museum facilities



[Hieroglyphic](#) decorations on the walls of the Grand Egyptian Museum

Logo design

On 10 June 2018, the museum's logo was revealed. The logo was designed by Tariq Atrissi.^[61] The cost of the design amounted to 800,000 Egyptian pounds, which included the costs of designing the museum exhibition implemented by the German company Atelier Bruckner.^[62]

Management

The GEM's management structure includes the Board of Trustees, the Board of Directors, and the Museum's CEO and vice presidents.

The Board of Trustees is an oversight body responsible for approving the Museum Authority's policies and plans.^[63] It consists of a 16-person council which sits for a term of 3 years. The composition, term length, and scope of work of the Board of Trustees are determined by the [President of Egypt](#).^[64]

Events

The museum has hosted different artistic and cultural events and venues since its partial opening. On 20 January 2023, the first musical concert held in the museum was given by Egyptian soprano [Fatma Said](#) with the United Philharmonic Orchestra & Choir, conducted by Nader Abbassi.^[65]